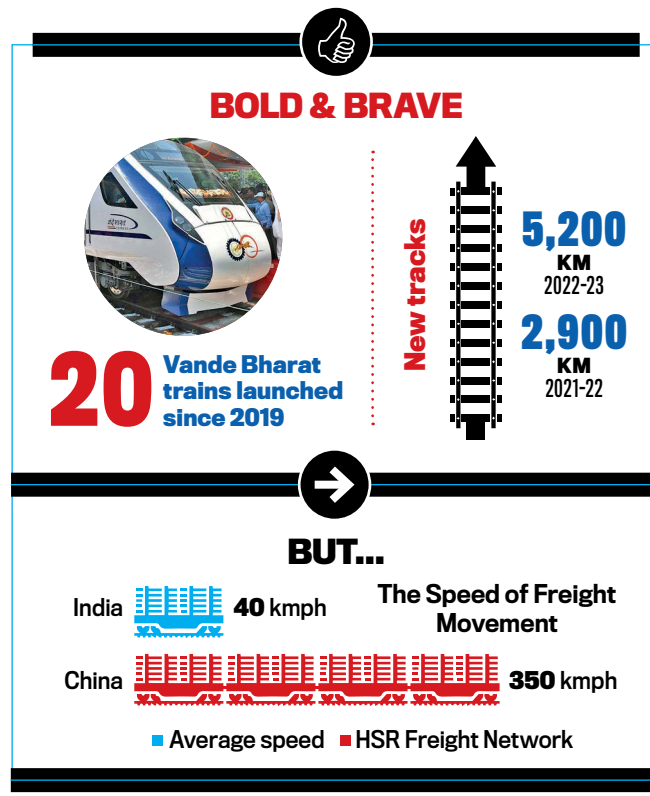


ANI

Ashwini Vaishnaw
Minister of Railways



as Vaishnaw had hoped they would, given the ambitious target to make 400 Vande Bharat trains operational by FY26 to provide a more comfortable journey than on the premium Rajdhani and Shatabdi Express trains. The existing Vande Bharat train-sets are chair cars used for 7-8 hour journeys. Prototypes are now being prepared to manufacture sleeper coaches as well. And the response has been encouraging. Minutes after the sale of tickets began for the latest Delhi-Dehradun Vande Bharat Express on May 27, it was booked to capacity for the first three days.

To meet the requirement of the ever-expanding railway network, the ministry is also adding new tracks at an unprecedented pace. An impressive 5,200 km of new tracks were laid in FY23, up from 2,900 km in FY22. "It's like adding the railway network of Switzerland in just a year," the minister is quick to add.

For years, the soft-spoken Vaishnaw had been assisting Modi from behind the scenes with inputs for reforms across sectors. Now, in the thick of things, he has used his sector-specific knowledge as well as communication skills to remove the most complex bottlenecks. The augmentation of the railways' capacity during the power crisis in March last year is a case in point. "I am new to politics," admits Vaishnaw. "But I have an understanding of railways and technology. I stick to what I know the best and try to deliver."

Among the various reforms, the ministry is deploying the indigenously developed automatic train protection system Kavach, redeveloping 1,275 railway stations, building the capacity to manufacture more efficient locomotives and coaches, and accelerating the execution of Dedicated Freight Corridors (DFCs). Since the inaugural train was flagged off on the DFC in December 2020, about 80 per cent of the tracks on both the Western and Eastern corridors have become operational, recording over 100,000 freight train journeys.

Segregating the slower freight trains to these dedicated greenfield tracks is allowing the railways to ensure a smoother journey on passenger trains and enhance freight train speeds. Figures on Statista show the average freight train speed in India at 23-24 km per hour in 2000-2020. It went up to 40 km per hour between 2020 and 2023. Though still no match for China's freight trains, which run at 350 km per hour on its high-speed rail network, Vaishnaw believes the Indian Railways is on the right track. ■